

A Walk Alone: Triggering Fear and Simulating Empathy to Raise Awareness about the Dangers Women Face when Walking Alone at Night

Triggering Fear and Simulating Empathy to Raise Awareness about the Dangers Women Face when Walking Alone at Night

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ABSTRACT

A Walk Alone is a virtual reality experience that simulates what it feels like to walk alone at night as a woman. The concept is inspired by the kidnapping and murder of Sarah Everard, a 33-year-old woman who went missing during her walk home from her friend's apartment in March 2021. It is one thing to discuss this universal issue and highlight the precautions women take when walking alone, but it is another thing to experience it. *A Walk Alone* focuses on displaying the vulnerability of the user by triggering multiple senses in the virtual reality environment. The experience is centered around a linear story involving (1) one night-city environment, (2) the user in first person point-of-view, (3) eerie sound design, and (5) dim street lighting.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Applied computing; • Arts and humanities; • Media arts; • Information Systems; • Information Systems application; • Multimedia Information Systems;

KEYWORDS

Virtual Reality, Simulation, Women Empowerment, Sexual Assault and Violence

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1 PROJECT CONCEPT

A Walk Alone is a virtual reality simulation that was created due to the gravity of how dangerous it can be for women to walk alone at night. An alarming number of women are victims of sexual assault or are not lucky enough to make it home alive. According to the Violence Against Women Prevalence Estimates report conducted by the World Health Organization between 2000 and 2018, around 736 million women globally have been subjected to physical or sexual violence in their lifetimes [World Health Organization 2018]. YouGov RealTime research states that 61% of American women regularly take precautions to avoid being sexually assaulted, as opposed to 26% of American men. Some of the precautions that women take include maintaining awareness of one's surroundings, having a phone prepared, avoiding certain areas, and informing others about one's location and schedule [Ballard 2019]. It is important to note that women can take all the precautions in order to make it home safely, but ultimately the root of the issue lies on the harasser.

2 BACKGROUND RESEARCH

Before developing *A Walk Alone*, it was vital to understand what virtual reality elements can elevate the impact of such a sensitive topic. Our research included looking into existing games and simulations that fit within the horror genre of virtual reality and other mediums. Phasmophobia [Phasmophobia 2020] sweeps the user up in a believable auditory experience that involves location-based sound as well as a variety of different sound effects, which are referenced in *A Walk Alone*. Other horror games like *Slender: The Arrival* and *Outlast* [Slender: The Arrival 2013 and Outlast 2013] played an important role in inspiring both dimly lit environments and eerie sound design to trigger emotional unease. The limited lighting in each of these four games allows the game designers to limit the path and vision of the users. By only lighting key sections of our environment, we deliberately guide our users through the city street environment of *A Walk Alone*. In addition, strategically placed construction assets and roadblocks further limit the user's path. Since our concept is based heavily on simulating the act of



Figure 1: Screenshots from A Walk Alone virtual reality simulation highlighting different scenes in first person point of view.

walking, it was important to research the different methods of locomotion in virtual reality, especially with regards to avoiding motion sickness. Our aim was to minimize locomotion discomfort while still mirroring the feeling of walking alone at night in real life. We looked at the locomotion within the game *Onward* [Onward 2016], which utilizes trackpad and gestural movement to navigate the virtual reality space; since the user is not moving in real life, this method may trigger motion sickness. A way to combat this is to restrict the field of view of the user when they are walking, or to use smooth and slow motion. We decided to use trackpad touch as our method for locomotion. To combat motion sickness, we maintained slow and controlled locomotion movement paired with a dimly lit environment that restricts the user’s peripheral vision.

3 PROJECT OBJECTIVE & USER EXPERIENCE

The goal of the simulation is to create an immersive experience that sheds light on the real dangers women face when walking home alone. The target users are men who are unaware of how dangerous it can be for women to walk alone at night, with a primary focus on men who need to be better allies for women in these situations. The virtual environment of *A Walk Alone* is dimly lit and claustrophobic in nature. Users navigate through sparsely lit darkness to emulate a sense of isolation and vulnerability (see Figure 1). To enhance user immersion and mimic the reality of the scenario, intentionally positioned lighting and diegetic mobile notification guides (see Figure 2) are the only tools used to assist the user to navigate the space. Once users reach the long dark alleyway, they encounter a replica of the real life “missing persons” poster of Sarah Everard, the woman whose tragedy reignited an international conversation about women’s safety in March 2021. This asset connects the game’s

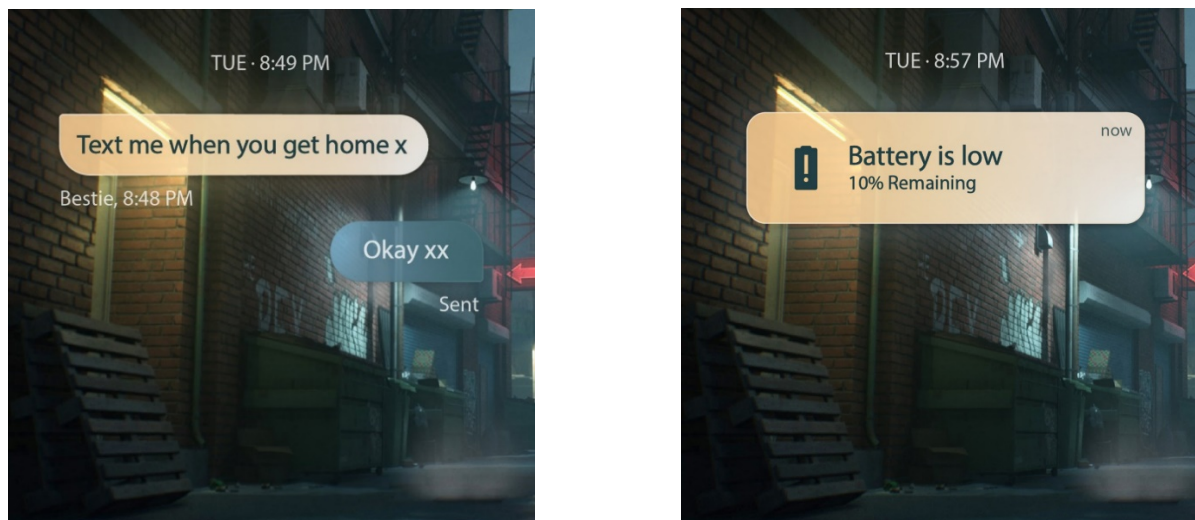


Figure 2: Two examples of mobile notifications acting as diegetic guides in the virtual reality simulation of A Walk Alone.

narrative to its social inspiration and encourages users to directly correlate their experiences in-game with the reflection of real-life dangers women face in society today.

It is vital for users to understand the real-life impact of A Walk Alone, therefore the main objective of the simulation is to trigger empathy within the user in order to raise awareness about the issue of women's safety. The poignancy of going through the walk from start to finish is intended to trigger fear, anxiety, and discomfort. According to preliminary observation from a public demonstration of A Walk Alone, a little over half of the users, most of whom identify as male, claimed to be knowledgeable of the dangers women face when walking alone at night. After experiencing A Walk Alone, the number increased significantly. The majority of users also claimed that they were fully immersed in the narrative and felt vulnerable during the simulation. It is important to also gauge how careful the users are of their presence and actions around women who are alone at night in order to constitute better allies. Only half of the

users stated that they are likely to be careful around women before the simulation, and approximately three fourths of the users stated they would be more careful after the experience. Users describing the experience as "rather terrifying", "uncomfortable", and "realistic" proves that A Walk Alone is making an impact and demonstrates the need to continue to discuss and confront the dangers women still face on a daily basis.

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